

In pushing the content that most matters to you to the forefront, Microsoft has also de-emphasised the traditional user interface “chrome” that can clutter up other smart phone UIs. The Windows Phone chrome consists of window and screen frames, borders, toolbars, and so on UI features that are found by default in the user experience. The content is the UI, and you interact directly with that content. Thus, the phone works the way you think, instead of forcing you to think about the way the device organises things as the iPhone does. Of course, you can’t just push common UI elements off to the side without making some trade-off. After all, this isn’t a user experience for toddlers. So Microsoft has based the Metro user experience, heavily, on nicely typographic text, or type. And while the notion of textual menus and UI elements as beautiful may sound illogical what is this, DOS? in use, the Windows Phone user experience like that of the Zune HD before it is elegant, expressive, and attractive. As important, it’s highly usable.

Authentic

This bit is, perhaps, the hardest to swallow. It seems that Microsoft is pushing perhaps a bit too hard to establish its new user experience model as not just a viable alternative to the competition, but as a completely superior way of doing things. As Microsoft has noted, “It’s a phone, not a PC.” The point being that while Windows may make plenty of sense on a PC, it doesn’t make a heck of a lot of sense on a device with a 4-inch screen. So Windows Phone is authentic, or true, to the device. The hardware is simple and modern by design, as is the software. There’s no decoration and no ornamentation on either, and no need for it.

What sets Metro apart

On any smart phone, the so-called “start experience” is what happens when you turn the device on at the beginning of the day and start interacting with it. It’s literally the starting point for your interactions with the device. Windows Phone provides two start experiences. The first is the default Start screen, which provides a handy “glance and go” view consisting of a customisable grid of live tiles, which access underlying hubs (panoramic experiences) and applications. This view is brand new to Windows Phone, and unlike anything on other smart phones or, for that matter, other Microsoft products.